# The Knowers

## By Helen Phillips

**ELLIE:** April 17, 2043. The knowledge heightened my life. The knowledge burdened my life. I regretted knowing. I was grateful to know.

## INTRODUCTION

*We all know our time here on earth is limited. But we don't know by how much. Are we better off not knowing when we'll die? Or would a countdown help us all to lead happier and more fulfilling lives? If you knew exactly when you were going to die, what would you change about the way you live?*

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**ELLIE:** **(Pg 1-14)** There are those who wish to know, and there are those who don't wish to know. At first Tem made fun of me when I claimed to be among the former; when he realized I meant it, he grew anxious, and when he realized I really did mean it, his anxiety morphed into terror.

**TEM:** *(tearfully) Why*? Why why *why*? This isn't only about you, you know. It affects me too. I don't want to sit

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around for a bunch of decades awaiting the worst day of my life.

**ELLIE:** If only I could have known it was possible to know and still have been fine with ignorance. But now that the technology had been mastered, the knowledge was available to every citizen for a nominal fee.

No way was I going to tell him about the bureaucratic office with its pale-yellow walls. It never ceases to amaze me that, even as our country forges into the future with ever more bedazzling devices and technologies, the archaic infrastructure rots away beneath our feet, the pavement and the rails, the schools and the DMV. In any case: Tem would not know, today or ever, about the place I'd gone, about the humming machine that looked like a low-budget ATM (could they really do no better?), about the chilly metal buttons of the keypad into which I punched my social security number after waiting in line behind other soon-to-be Knowers. There was a silent, grim camaraderie among us as I glanced down at the paper the slot spat out at me, as I folded it up and stepped away from the machine.

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**TEM:** *(holding out his hand, palm quivering but in a jovial voice)* Okay, lay it on me.

**ELLIE:** The words were light, almost jovial, but I could tell they were the five hardest words he'd ever uttered. I swore to never again accuse Tem of being less than courageous. And I applauded myself for going straight from the bureaucratic office to the canal, for standing there above the sickly greenish water, for glancing once more at the piece of paper, for tearing it into as many scraps as possible, for dropping it into the factory-scented breeze. I'd thought it was the right thing to do, and now I knew it was. Tem should not have to live under the same roof with that piece of paper. *(to Tem, brightly)* I don't have it.

**TEM:** *(gasping)* You don't? You mean you changed your —

**ELLIE:** I got it. I got it, and then I got rid of it, after memorizing it, of course. I ***know***.

**TEM:** You *know*! *You* know! *(softly, with trepidation)* Tell me.

**ELLIE:** Are you sure? *(to audience)* Suddenly it seemed quite likely that I'd made a catastrophic error. The kind of error that could ruin the rest of my life. I became

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wildly scared; I who'd so boldly sought knowledge now did not even dare give voice to a date. *(to Tem)* April 17 —

**TEM:** *(covering his ears)* Stop! Never mind! I don't want to know! Don't! Don't don't don't!

**ELLIE:** *OKAY*. *(to audience)* It was lonely to hold this knowledge. April 17, 2043: a tattoo inside my brain. But it was as it should be. It was the choice I had made. Tem wished to be spared, and spare him I would.

It was an okay lifespan. Not enough — is it ever enough? — but enough to have a life; to work a job, to raise children, perhaps to meet a grandchild or two. Short, yes; but not tragically short. And so in many ways I could live a life like any other. I could go blithely along, indulging my petty concerns, lacking perspective, frequently forgetting I wasn't immortal. Yet it would be a lie if I said a single day passed without me thinking about April 17, 2043.

I began to mark April 17. I would buy myself a gift: a bar of dark chocolate -- a new dress. I always felt extravagant on April 17; I'd leave a tip of twenty-five

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percent, hand out a five-dollar bill to any vagrant who happened to cross my path. *You can't take it with you* and all that. I'd make a reservation for us at a fancy restaurant; I'd schedule a weekend getaway. Luxuries we spent the whole rest of the year carefully avoiding.

My life would seem normal — bland, really — to an outside observer, but I tell you that for me it has been rich, layered and rich. There have been so many moments, almost an infinity of moments — soaping up the kids' hair when they were tiny, walking from the parking lot to the office on a bird-studded Friday morning. What can I say. I don't mean to be sentimental, but these are not small things. ***The deeper that sorrow carves into your being, the more joy you can contain*.** This is no time to go into the ups and downs, the stillbirths and the car accident and the estrangement, but I believe the above statement to be true. April 17, 2043. The knowledge heightened my life. The knowledge burdened my life. I regretted knowing. I was grateful to know.

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I've never been the type to bungee jump or skydive, yet in many small ways I lived more courageously. I knew when to fear death, yes, but that also meant I knew when not to fear it. I'd gone to the grocery store during times of quarantine. I'd volunteered at the hospital, driven in blizzards, ridden roller coasters so rickety Tem wouldn't let the kids on them. But I have to admit that December 31, 2042, was a fearful day for me.

We'd hosted everyone for a last supper of the year, both children and their spouses, and our first grandchild, bright as a brand-new penny. At the dinner table, our radiant daughter and her husband announced that they were expecting in August. Amid the raucous cheers and exclamations, no one noticed that I wasn't cheering. The child I'd miss by four months. The ache was vast. I couldn't speak.

I stood in the bathroom, clinging to the sink, staring at my face in the mirror until it no longer felt like my face. This would develop into a distasteful but addictive habit over the course of the next three and a half months. I got pretty good at hiding my dread. From Tem, and even

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at times from myself. We planted bulbs; we bought a cooler for summer picnics. I pretended and pretended; it felt nice to pretend.

Yet when Tem asked, on April 10, what I'd planned for this year's getaway, the veil fell away. Given the circumstance, I had — of course — neglected to make any plans for the 17th. The dread rushed outward from my gut until my entire body was hot and cold. Panicking, I looked across the table at Tem, who was gazing at me hopefully, the way he'd looked at me for almost four decades. Tem and I — we've been so lucky in love. *(to Tem; choked up)* Tem . . . *(to audience)* And then he realized.

**TEM:** Damn it, Ellie! Why'd you have to — !

**ELLIE:** I quietly quit my job and Tem took the week off. We spent every minute together and invited the blissfully ignorant kids out for brunch. Everything I saw — a gas station, a tree, a flagpole — I thought how it would go on existing, just the same.

On the morning of April 17, 2043, I was half-amazed to open my eyes to the light. Six hours and four minutes

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into the day, and I was alive. Petrified, scared to move even a muscle, I wondered how death would come for me. Would it be a heart attack, a stroke, a tumble down the basement stairs? I had the inclination to stay in bed, but by 10 a.m. I was still alive and feeling antsy, bold. Why lie here whimpering when it was coming for me no matter what? *(To Tem)* Let's go out. It's not like I'm sick or anything.

*(to audience)* The outside ***seemed*** more dangerous — there it could be a falling branch, a malfunctioning crane, a truck raring up onto the sidewalk. But it could just as easily catch me at home — misplaced rat poison, a chunk of meat lodged in my throat, a slick bathtub.

We walked, looking this way and that as we went, hyperaware of everything. Vigilant. I felt like a newborn person, passing so alertly through the world. We sat in a park, each additional moment a small shock. Come 11:45 pm, we were inside, brushing our teeth, shaking. Would I simply collapse onto the floor, or would it be a burglar with a weapon?

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What if there had been an error? Remembering back to that humble machine, that thin scrap of paper, the cold buttons of the keypad, I indulged in the fantasy I'd avoided over the years. It suddenly seemed possible that I'd punched my social in wrong, one digit off. Or that there had been some kind of bureaucratic mistake, some malfunction deep within the machine. Or perhaps I'd mixed up the digits — April 13, 2047. If I lived beyond April 17, 2043, where would the new boundaries of my life lie?

We stood there staring at each other in the bathroom mirror. This time I didn't fall into my own reflection — I was looking at Tem. Why had it never occurred to me that it might be something that would kill Tem too? In all of these years, truly, I had never once entertained that possibility. But it could be a meteorite, a bomb, an earthquake, a fire. I unlocked my eyes from Tem's reflection and clung to him like I was clinging to a cliff, and he clung right back. I counted ten tense seconds. The pulse in his neck.

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11:54 pm on April 17, 2043. We are both alive and well. Yet I mustn't get ahead of myself. There are still six minutes remaining. *[Six . . . Five . . . Four . . . ]*

## SOURCE INFORMATION

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